

YOU'RE NOT A spreadsheet. You're a person. A screwed up, emotional person.

It took me a while to figure this out, but once it clicked I realized it's one of the most important parts of finance.

With it comes something that often goes overlooked: Do not aim to be coldly rational when making financial decisions. Aim to just be pretty reasonable. Reasonable is more realistic and you have a better chance of sticking with it for the long run, which is what matters most when managing money.

To show you what I mean, let me tell you the story of a guy who tried to cure syphilis with malaria.

Julius Wagner-Jauregg was a 19th-century psychiatrist with two unique skills: He was good at recognizing patterns, and what others saw as “crazy” he found merely “bold.”

His specialty was patients with severe neurosyphilis—then a fatal diagnosis with no known treatment. He began noticing a pattern: syphilis patients tended to recover if they had the added misfortune of having prolonged fevers from an unrelated ailment.

Wagner-Jauregg assumed this was due to a hunch that had been around for centuries but doctors didn't understand well: fevers play a role in helping the body fight infection.

So he jumped to the logical conclusion.

In the early 1900s Wagner-Jauregg began injecting patients with low-end strains of typhoid, malaria, and smallpox to trigger fevers strong enough to kill off their syphilis. This was as dangerous as it sounds. Some of his patients died from the treatment. He eventually settled on a weak version of malaria, since it could be effectively countered with quinine after a few days of bone-rattling fevers.

After some tragic trial and error his experiment worked. Wagner-Jauregg reported that 6 in 10 syphilis patients treated with “malariotherapy” recovered, compared to around 3 in 10 patients left alone. He won the Nobel Prize in medicine in 1927. The organization today notes: “The main